

# ART & CULTURE



## INDIAN PAINTINGS

**MODULE - 4**

**MINIATURE PAINTINGS**



# CLASSIFICATION OF INDIAN PAINTINGS

## MINIATURE PAINTINGS



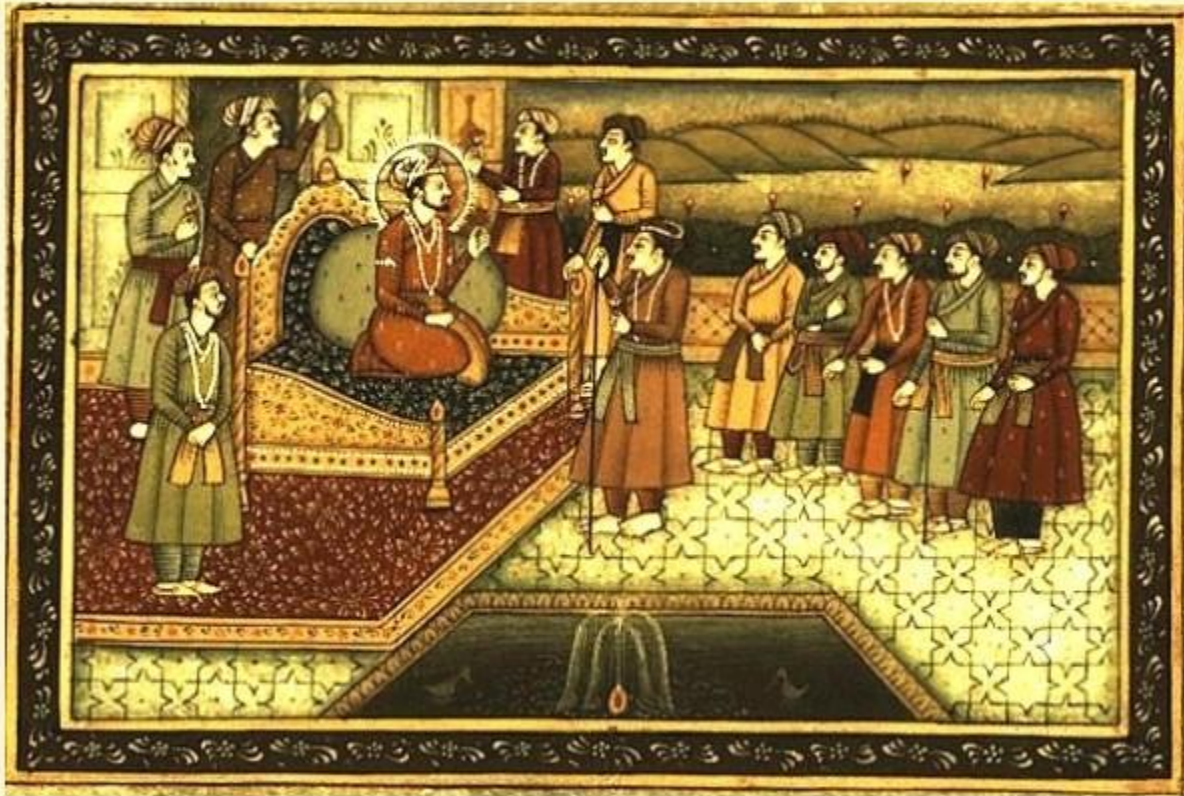
**Bani Thani painting of  
Kishangarh school**

- 1** The word 'miniature' is derived from the Latin word 'Minium', which means red lead paint.
- 2** This paint was used in the illuminated manuscripts during the Renaissance period.
- 3** It is generally assumed to have come from the root word minimum, which would mean that they were small in size.
- 4** The Indian subcontinent has long traditions of these miniature paintings and many schools developed that have difference in composition and perspective.
- 5** Miniatures are small and detailed paintings.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

## TECHNIQUES OF MINIATURE PAINTINGS



- 1 There are several preconditions that are necessary to be fulfilled for making Miniature paintings.
  - The painting should not be larger than 25 square inch.
  - The subject of the painting should be painted in not more than  $\frac{1}{6}^{\text{th}}$  of the actual size.
- 2 For example, an adult head of 9 inches would not be painted larger than 1.5 inches.
- 3 In most of the Indian miniature paintings, the human figurine is seen with the side profile.



## MINIATURE PAINTINGS

### TECHNIQUES OF MINIATURE PAINTINGS



**Bani Thani famously known as Indian Monalisa**

- 4** They usually have bulging eyes, pointed nose and slim waist.
- 5** In the Rajasthan miniatures the skin colour of the characters is brown, while in the Mughal paintings they are generally fairer.
- 6** Furthermore, the colour of divine beings like Lord Krishna is blue.
- 7** The women figurines have long hair and the colour of their eyes and hair are generally black.
- 8** Men generally wear traditional clothes and have a turban on their head.

# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

## EARLY MINIATURE



- 1** Miniature paintings were often painted for either books or albums, on perishable material including paper, palm leaves and cloth.
- 2** Developed almost as a reaction to the enormous wall paintings, the art of miniature painting developed between 9<sup>th</sup> and 11<sup>th</sup> centuries.
- 3** This kind of painting can be attributed to the eastern and western regions.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

## VARIOUS SCHOOLS OF MINIATURE PAINTINGS

- 1) The Pala School
- 2) Western Indian School
- 3) Other Isolated Styles
- 4) The Mughal School
- 5) The Deccani School
  - a) Ahmednagar
  - b) Bijapur
  - c) Golkonda
  - d) Hyderabad
  - e) Tanjore
- 6) The Central India and Rajasthani school
  - a) Malwa
  - b) Mewar
  - c) Burdi
  - d) Kota
  - e) Amber-Jaipur
  - f) Marwar
  - g) Bikaner
  - h) Kishangarh
- 7) The Pahari School
  - a) Basholi
  - b) Guler
  - c) Kangra
  - d) Kulu-Mandi
- 8) The Orissa School

# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

1

## PALA SCHOOL OF ART



1

This school was flourishing during 750-1150 AD.

2

These paintings are generally found as a part of manuscripts and were generally executed on palm leaf.

3

The Buddhist monks mostly used them and as their religion practiced non-violence against all living beings there was a stipulation to use only banana or coconut tree leaves.

4

These paintings are characterised by sinuous lines and subdued tones of the background imagery.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

1

## PALA SCHOOL OF ART



**5** There are lonely single figures in the paintings and one rarely finds group paintings.

**6** They have simple compositions and were patronised by some of those rulers who promoted Buddhism.

**7** The proponents of the Vajrayana school of Buddhism also used and patronised these paintings.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

## 2

## WESTERN INDIAN SCHOOL

- 1 This school traces its origin to Gujarat and Mewar region in Rajasthan.
- 2 It was the predominant school of painting in western India during 11<sup>th</sup> and 15<sup>th</sup> century.
- 3 The most common themes of these paintings were Jain and in the later period the Vaishanava School appropriated them too.
- 4 They brought in the concept of Gita Govinda and secular love into these paintings that were otherwise dominated by the Jain iconography.
- 5 In the early Jain phase the paintings were made on Palm leaf but in the later period they were made on paper.
- 6 Even though the paintings were made as illustrations for books they did not develop a different style but were mural paintings in a reduced dimension.
- 7 The colours used in the paintings had symbolic meaning and they usually used red, yellow and ochre.
- 8 In the later phase, they used bright and gold colour.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

2

## WESTERN INDIAN SCHOOL



Kalpasutra

- 9 Furthermore, the features of the human figures depicted in the paintings have fish-shaped bulging eyes, a pointed nose and a double chin.
- 10 They tried to begin the trend to make angular faces in the third and fourth profile.
- 11 The figures are usually stiff and even the ornamentation is carefully done.
- 12 The female figurines have enlarged hips and breasts.
- 13 The animal and bird figurines in the paintings are represented as toys.
- 14 The most famous example is of Kalpasutra and the Kalakachya Katha from 15<sup>th</sup> century.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

3

## TRANSITION PERIOD MINIATURE

- 1 The coming of the Muslims on the Indian subcontinent was a harbinger of change and brought forth a cultural renaissance in the 14<sup>th</sup> century.



Veerabhadra temple

- 2 One should not say that the Islamic styles took over, as the traditional style of paintings survived in the western Indian courts and a cultural synthesis took place.
- 3 In the southern state of Vijaynagar, a different style was emerging that was closer to the Deccan style of painting.
- 4 The best example of this period would be the paintings at Virabhadra temple, where ceilings are as long as 11 meters and are painted at the borders with abstract motifs.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

3

## TRANSITION PERIOD MINIATURE



Lepakshi paintings of Veerabhadra temple

5 The style that developed was of the Lepakshi paintings which can be characterised by the earthy tones.

6 The colours are applied in a flat manner and the dress and human outlines are demarcated in black.

7 The view of the faces is from a three quarter angle and gives a detached appearance.

8 The landscapes are full of trees, rocks and other designs that do not try to replicate the natural appearance of the subject.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

4

## MINIATURE ART DURING DELHI SULTANATE



Nimatnama

- 1 These paintings tried to bring together the Persian elements of their origins with the Indian traditional elements.
- 2 They gave preference to illustrated manuscripts and one of the finest examples from this period is the Nimatnama during the reign of Nasir Shah who ruled over Mandu.
- 3 This manuscript shows the synthesis of the indigenous and Persian styles.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

4

## MINIATURE ART DURING DELHI SULTANATE



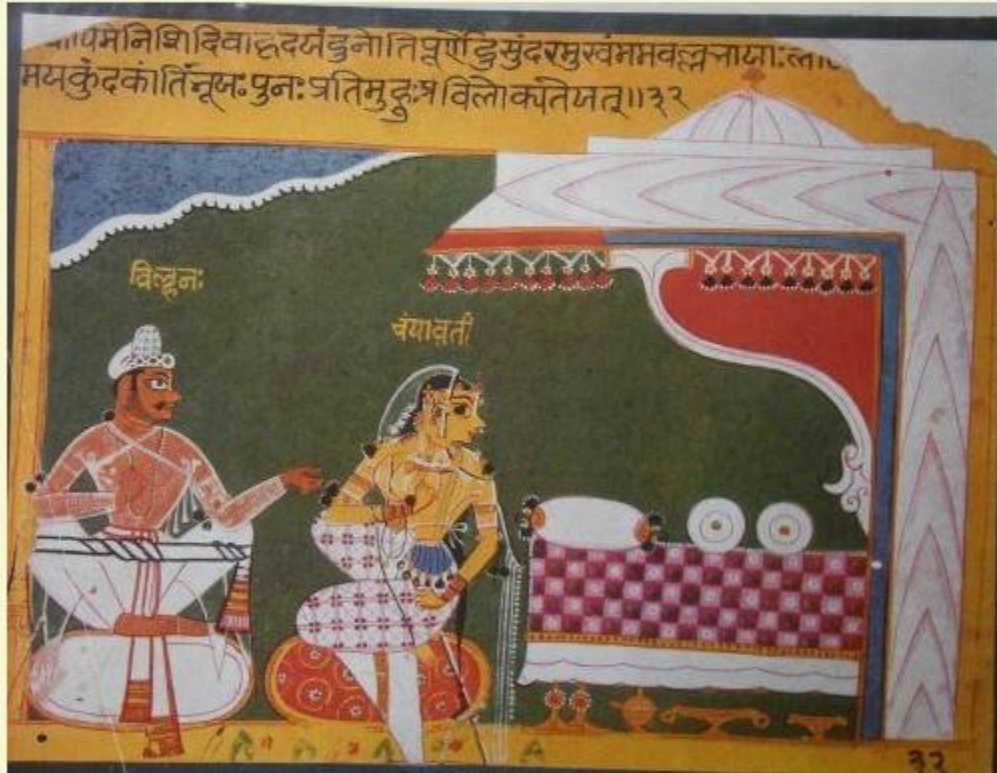
An illustrated manuscript of Nimatnama (cookery book)



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

4

## MINIATURE ART DURING DELHI SULTANATE



4 Apart from this another style represented by a group of miniatures was present designated as the "**Kulhadar Group**".

5 This group includes illustrations of the 'Chaurapanchasika' - "**Fifty Verses of the Thief**" by Bilhan, the Gita Govinda, the Bhagavata Purana and Ragamala.

6 The style of these miniatures is marked by the use of brilliant contrasting colours, vigorous and angular drawing, **transparent drapery** and the appearance of conical caps 'Kulha' on which turbans are worn by the male figures.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

4

## MINIATURE ART DURING DELHI SULTANATE



7

Kulhadar Group also became the basis of the Sultanate formulae.

8

Three major styles emerged that dominated the medieval landscape-  
Mughal, Rajput and Deccan.

9

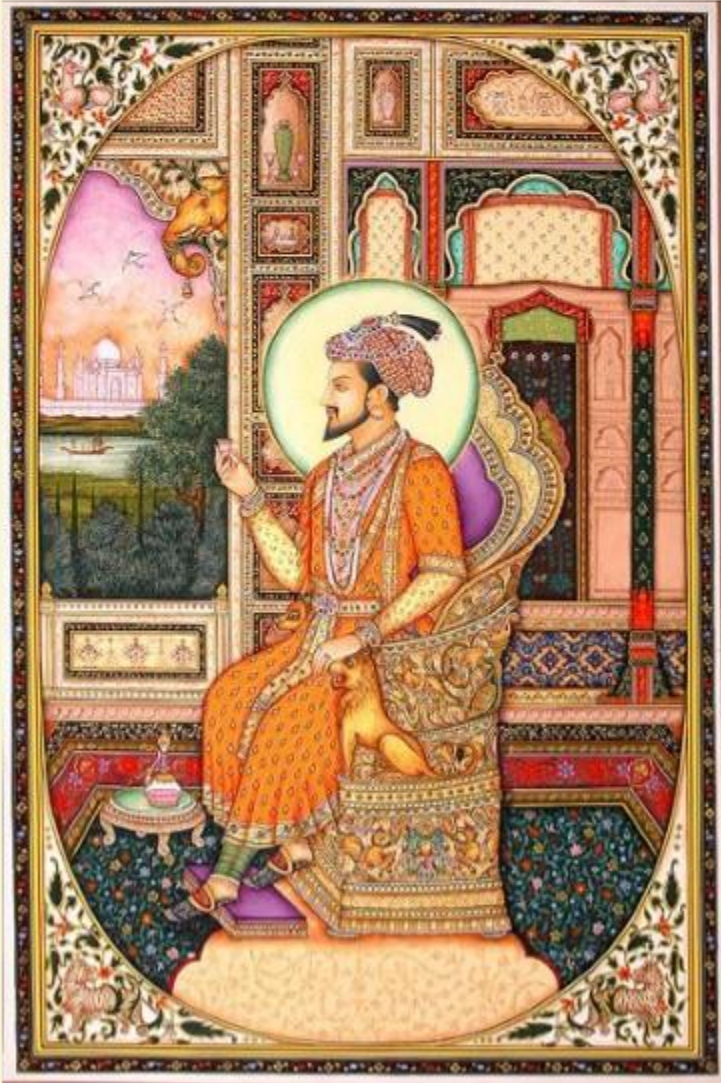
They took from the sultanate precedents but developed their own individuality.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

5

## MUGHAL ERA SCHOOL



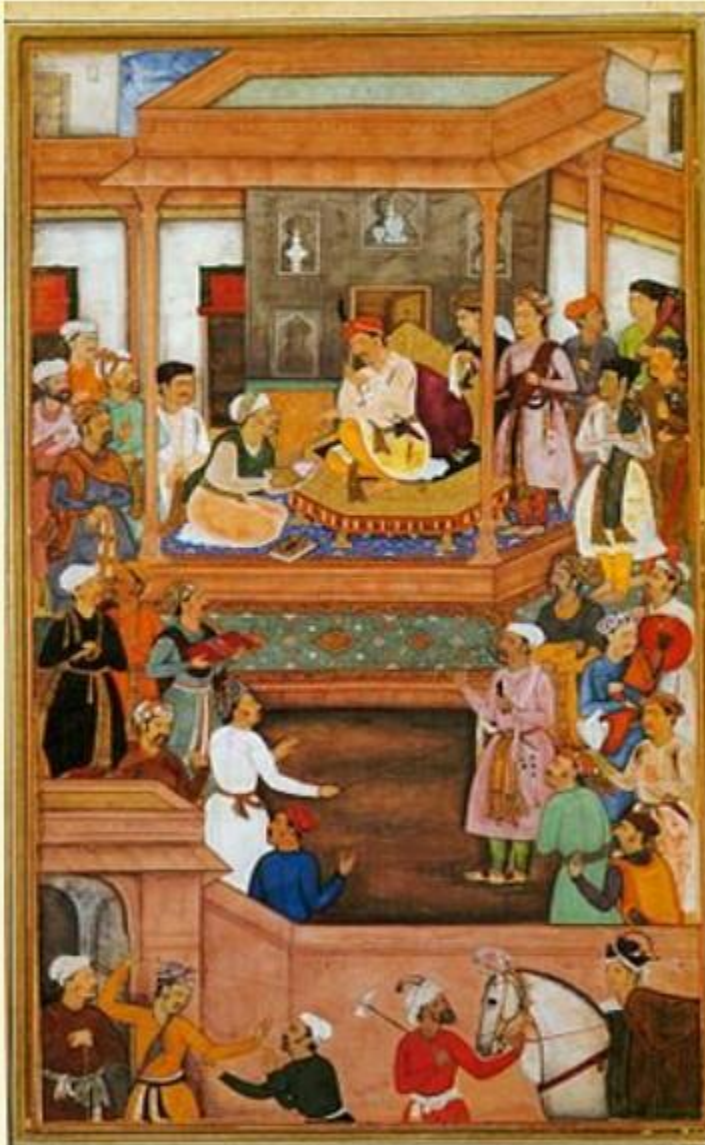
- 1 The paintings made in the Mughal period had a distinctive style as they were drawing from Persian antecedents.
- 2 There was a change in colour palette, themes and forms.
- 3 The focus shifted from depicting the god to glorifying the ruler and showing his life.
- 4 They focused on hunting scenes, historical events and other court related paintings.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

5

## MUGHAL ERA SCHOOL



**5** The Mughal paintings brought together Persian naturalistic style with the opulence of a great dynasty and created some beautifully illustrated folios.

**6** These paintings were considered unique because of the use of brilliant colours.

**7** The painters were supposed to concentrate on ensuring the accuracy of line drawing.

**8** Except religious paintings, the Mughals were known for their diverse themes.



# MINIATURE PAINTINGS

5

## MUGHAL ERA SCHOOL



**9** Even though they made only miniature paintings, the illustration in paintings are considered amongst the most unique paintings in the world.

**10** They brought the technique of foreshortening to the Indian painter's repertoire. Under this technique, "objects were drawn in a way that they look closer and smaller than they really are."

**11** The styles of paintings changes under the successive rulers.



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**OUR TEAM**

G. V. Rao

K. Srikanth

D. Sunil Kumar

L. V. Krishna

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